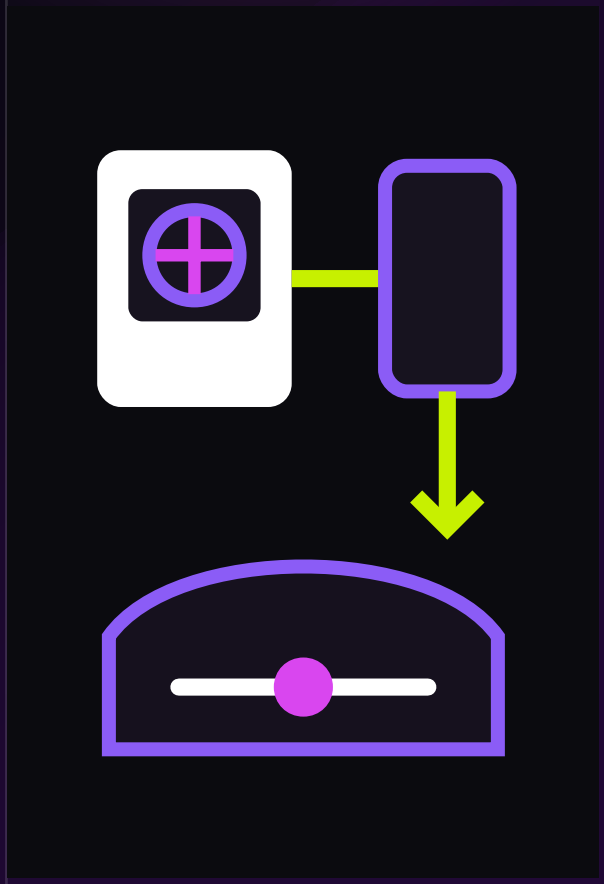
SOFTETHER MASQUERADE HUNT

Hunts SoftEther clients masquerading as Windows system binaries outside system directories.

HUNTING QUERY

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM



REPORT DATE
12 October 2026

STATUS
Untested implementation sketch

PRIMARY PLATFORM
Microsoft Defender XDR

OPERATIONAL VALUE
8.0 / 10

EXECUTIVE ASSESSMENT

Decision, confidence and evidence boundary.

ASSESSMENT

OPERATIONAL VALUE

8.0

Hunts SoftEther clients masquerading as Windows system binaries outside system directories.

CLASSIFICATION

Hunting query

Medium confidence. Source-supported campaign evidence; environmental prevalence is not validated.

1 primary table
1 primary query
0 production claims
4 validation gates

Evidence boundary

A filename and path match does not prove SoftEther content, malicious use, compromise, or Integrity Tech attribution.

BEHAVIOR AND EVIDENCE

Observed facts separated from analytical scope.

MECHANICS

#	Source-supported fact
1	A joint advisory states that actors installed SoftEther clients for persistence and C2 obfuscation.
2	Windows installers were downloaded with PowerShell or living-off-the-land binaries.
3	Observed installers were often named conhost.exe or dllhost.exe.

Detection hypothesis

If the published behavior occurs in a covered endpoint or cloud workload, DeviceProcessEvents should retain the campaign-specific evidence used by this hunt.

Unconfirmed elements

A filename and path match does not prove SoftEther content, malicious use, compromise, or Integrity Tech attribution.

ATT&CK: T1133 · T1036.003

TELEMETRY CONTRACT

Collection prerequisites and field reliability.

TELEMETRY

REQUIRED

DeviceProcessEvents

Microsoft Defender XDR advanced hunting coverage must retain the fields referenced by the query.

OPTIONAL ENRICHMENT

Identity, device, network, file reputation, prevalence, owner, change record, and adjacent-event context.

Requirement	Decision
Primary platform	Microsoft Defender XDR
Primary table	DeviceProcessEvents
Query status	Untested implementation sketch
Classification	Hunting; no alerting before validation

Coverage caveat

An empty result may mean no match, missing telemetry, retention gaps, parser differences, or field sparsity.

PRIMARY KQL

Source-supported conditions with investigable output.

HUNTING

STATUS

Hunting query — Untested implementation sketch

KQL — UNTESTED

```
// Integrity Tech / Flax Typhoon - masqueraded SoftEther installer execution
// Platform: Microsoft Defender XDR Advanced Hunting
// Status: Hunting query - Untested implementation sketch
// Confidence: Medium
// MITRE ATT&CK: T1133, T1036.003
// Required telemetry: Microsoft Defender for Endpoint DeviceProcessEvents
// Evidence: AA26-281A states that actors downloaded SoftEther installers and
// often named them conhost.exe or dllhost.exe to resemble Windows binaries.
// This query deliberately excludes the legitimate Windows binary directories.
// A result is not proof that the binary is SoftEther or actor-controlled.

DeviceProcessEvents
| where FileName in~ ("conhost.exe", "dllhost.exe")
| where not(FolderPath startswith @"C:\Windows\System32\")
| where not(FolderPath startswith @"C:\Windows\SysWOW64\")
| project
    Timestamp,
    DeviceName,
    AccountName,
    FileName,
    FolderPath,
    ProcessCommandLine,
    ProcessVersionInfoCompanyName,
    ProcessVersionInfoOriginalFileName,
    SHA1,
    InitiatingProcessFileName,
    InitiatingProcessFolderPath,
    InitiatingProcessCommandLine,
    InitiatingProcessAccountName,
    ReportId
| order by Timestamp desc
```

TRIAGE AND TUNING

Human validation before response.

WORKFLOW

1

Preserve

Retain the raw event, device or account, timestamps, and campaign-matched values.

2

Confirm

Validate field semantics and determine whether the matched object exists.

3

Enrich

Add reputation, prevalence, owner, identity, network, and adjacent-event context.

4

Scope

Search for related execution, persistence, access, and follow-on activity.

Expected benign overlap

Administration, software development, security testing, automation, content inspection, shared infrastructure, or legitimate files may overlap. Tune only after ownership and prevalence are established.

Response boundary

A filename and path match does not prove SoftEther content, malicious use, compromise, or Integrity Tech attribution.

VALIDATION GATES

Controlled tests and promotion criteria.

QUALITY CONTROL

Validation steps

1. Confirm the primary table and every projected field exist.
2. Replay an authorized benign event matching the query shape.
3. Measure at least 30 days of tenant prevalence and benign overlap.
4. Verify every result retains sufficient evidence for triage.

Decision criteria

Success: the test is visible and real matches remain attributable.

Rejection: benign activity dominates or the campaign artifact is no longer reliable.

Failure: required telemetry or fields are unavailable.

Promotion gate

Do not promote to production until telemetry, prevalence, ownership, and false-positive handling are demonstrated in the target environment.

CONCLUSION AND REFERENCES

Coverage statement and document control.

FINAL

CONCLUSION

Hunting query

Hunts SoftEther clients masquerading as Windows system binaries outside system directories.

A filename and path match does not prove SoftEther content, malicious use, compromise, or Integrity Tech attribution.

MITRE ATT&CK

T1133 · T1036.003

References

1. INTEGRITY TECH / FLAX TYPHOON - REFERENCES
2. Prepared: 2026-10-12
3. PRIMARY GOVERNMENT TECHNICAL RESEARCH
4. FBI, CISA, NSA, NCSC-UK and international partners
5. AA26-281A - Chinese Government-linked Cyber Threat Actors Combine Automated
6. and Hands-on Hacking Tools to Steal Sensitive Data
7. hxxps://www[.]ic3[.]gov/CSA/2026/261008[.]pdf
8. Published 2026-10-08; accessed 2026-10-12.
9. Observed activity: as early as 2017; initial access details since at least
10. mid-January 2021; specific compromise windows vary by incident.
11. U.S. Department of Justice
12. Justice Department and FBI Seize Vulnerability Scanning and Spear Phishing

Document control

Canonical locked typography and layout. Only the campaign illustration on page 1 is variable.